Path



STEEPED IN SUSPENSE
Dhootha director Vikram K. Kumar on set, and (far left) Naga Chaitanya

'Should I be doing this at this point of my career?'" he says. "I was very clear that [on OTT] I don't want to do the kind of roles I'm doing in cinema. I'd like to come out of my comfort zone and do what I cannot do on the big screen."

In *Dhootha*, Chaitanya plays Sagar Varma, not the most upright journalist, who finds himself receiving old newspapers with strange clues that put his and the lives of his loved ones in danger. The character is in stark contrast to the romantic hero image he has carved for himself in Telugu films. "Sagar's got shades of black, white and grey, which really intrigued me," he adds. "I got to explore these layers which I didn't get to do as an actor in cinema."

Grandson of Telugu cinema legend Akkineni Nageswara Rao and eldest son of popular actor Nagarjuna, Naga Chaitanya was destined to be in the movies. He made his acting debut in 2009 with *Josh*. "I didn't know the gravity of the image my family had with the public. It's only after I stepped into films and then experienced the kind of fan following that came because of my father and grandfather that I realised that there is this huge responsibility," he says. Films like *Ye Maaya Chesave*, *Premam* and *Love Story* would bring him acclaim, but the actor is aware the platform he's afforded because of his roots. "I feel I'm allowed a few more mistakes than someone who's not got this film background," he says.

Even after 14 years in the film industry, he admits he has yet to figure out a path for himself. Living with comparisons has become easier. "It's a lifelong process," he says. "I'm trying to be unique to myself." Much like his father who had a few Hindi films to his credit, Chaitanya made his Hindi debut last year with a supporting part in the Aamir Khan-produced *Laal Singh Chaddha*. Chaitanya played the desi iteration of Bubba in the Forrest Gump adaptation. *Laal Singh Chaddha* didn't perform to the lofty box office standards that are attached to a Khan film, but for Chaitanya, it was a transformative experience. He says, "Being able to learn how he [Aamir Khan] approaches the craft and to observe him up close...for me it was like going back to school literally. I think what I learned in those six months, I haven't learned in the last decade." The film was also an example of how the linguistic boundaries between film industries have blurred in the last few years. "People have gotten used to watching films with subtitles. Previously, South films never got these [many] screens and the dubbing market was also non-existent. There's greater exposure now," says Chaitanya. While many top Telugu actors are yet to take to OTT, for Chaitanya it's a matter of keeping up with the times. "I think the audience is consuming content from different platforms and in different ways," he says. An avid consumer of streaming programming himself, Chaitanya in *Dhootha* is an actor recognising the need to reinvent—and surprise his audience in the process. He calls the actor in it his "alter ego". Says Naga Chaitanya, "There's so much talent around doing so many new things coupled with the audience being exposed to content from all over the world. I don't think we can afford to be comfortable because we will either burn out or we'll become monotonous after a point." ■

Suhani Singh

LOVECRAFT COUNTRY
(Amazon Prime)



A black man travels through racially segregated America of the 1950s in search of his father, only to find his journey routinely hindered by terrifying monsters and ruthless white men.

MIDNIGHT MASS
(Netflix)



Mike Flanagan has created an impressive roster of horror fare for Netflix (*The Haunting of Hill House*, *The Fall of the House of Usher*), but this by far might be its most engrossing watch. It cleverly shows how religion is the opium of the people and can be misused to divide and destruct.